

payments space,” he says. Bindra points out that Flipkart was “massively funded” in its initial days and had a head start over Amazon India. “They built categories like mobiles, fashion and home appliances very well,” he says.

The firm used its tech prowess to customise its India business. Kishore Thota, Director (Shopping Experience), India & Emerging Markets, Amazon, who moved from Seattle in the initial phase, says India became the most visited Amazon location at one point.

Amazon first figured out the ecosystem, with over 25 languages and a heterogeneous customer base. “Everything was built specifically for India from the seller’s or the customer’s side. Some of those learnings are moving to other markets,” Thota says. Take the case of the emerging shopper who is new to e-commerce. “For that person, the trust factor is still being built, and the frequency of shopping is a little low,” Thota says. This emerging shopper can be found worldwide, and Amazon is taking its India lessons places.

For instance, there are customers in advanced markets, such as the US, who prefer paying in cash, and customers in Mexico and Brazil who opt for credit. “India then becomes a base market for the emerging shopper worldwide. The priority is to solve for India and eventually look for similar scenarios elsewhere,” Thota says.

## FROM ORDER TO DELIVERY

Amazon’s ‘fulfilment’ centres are the engines of its success. Taking us on a walk through BLR8, one such fulfilment centre, Abhinav Singh, VP (Operations), says that a product shows up on the website the moment it is stocked. Just BLR8



**“Amazon had set processes and global-scale experience... It became easier for them to scale up quickly with the right local talent and a level of localisation”**

**NEIL SHAH**

RESEARCH VICE PRESIDENT  
AND PARTNER, COUNTERPOINT  
RESEARCH



**“Amazon has taken a more long-term approach here (in India) with a lot of emphasis on localisation initiatives. They needed a large market like India since China was difficult for political and localisation reasons”**

**JASPREET BINDRA**

FOUNDER, TECH WHISPERER UK

sprawls across 400,000 sq. ft and 2.3 million cubic ft. Why 400,000 sq. ft? “We hit upon this as the ideal number. Larger buildings could reduce supply chain costs, but you will also have a higher degree of automation,” he says. “The priority is to get it right on pricing, selection and convenience.”

Plus, there is a new way Indians are shopping: live commerce. India is witnessing more live commerce on video, where customers can come into contact with an influ-

encer or use AI tools. A buyer can virtually place a television using augmented reality or AR to see what it might look like in a living room. Costs are saved here since a shopper typically orders three curtains, for instance, and then buys one after trying them out. “We are a native technology company, and the question we always ask ourselves relates to how we can automate something,” says Thota.

The Indian market means unpredictability and disruption.